

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles
Pentecost 8
Another Kind of Freedom ~ Truth Telling
26 July 2026

COMMUNION
NEO Voice Festival Choir

Michael away

Preaching: LVF
Worship Leading: Rev. Chad Tanaka Pack & Meg Russett

Organ Prelude-Concert

Improvisation

Sandra ?, Cathedral Choir Member

Everything is Immanent – Jason Olshan

Air – Saginaw Rozzo

Dr. Abraham Ross, *Guest Organist*

Alleluyas – Simon Preston

Sienna Stribling, 2026 N.E.O. Organ Fellow

Chiming of the Hour

[Chad and Meg to center chancel]

Welcome

CTP

Words of Gathering

MR & CTP

MR: As we greet this new day, let us gather our courage.

We can do hard things:
Brave things
Beautiful things
Risky and transformative things.

CTP: The Sacred journeys with us
toward freedom:

*For the sake of the collective life
For the sake of disrupting evil
For the sake of the human soul.*

MR: In this our time and place:
*We are called and accompanied.
We are never alone.*

So, in this time set apart -
may our hearts be encouraged
for all that lies before us.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

[adpt/enfleshedmjadekaiser]

CTP: *Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering*

[Choir mics on for hymn leaders]

***Hymn Of Gathering**

[Chad center chancel]

Prayer of Confession & Awareness

CTP

God of freedom and liberation,
you have given us the law, spoken through prophets,
and provided us with the Spirit to help guide us
in love and justice.
Still we struggle.

*The complexities of life and the challenges of
being human often win over.
In our pain, we do harm one another,
we do not intervene when our neighbors are targeted,
and we become possessive of power and resources.*

Yet you do not leave us where we are.
You call us to a new way of life and you ask us
to make your dream for this world a reality.

*Forgive us, O God, where we have failed
and surround us with your never ending love and hope,*

as you ground our lives in mutual care and connection.

*We pray this with gratitude for your love and grace and mercy.
Amen and Amen!*

[All turn towards choir]

Introit

“Analogy of Being” part III
N.E.O. Festival Choir and Cathedral Choir

Fahad Siadat

[Meg to lectern]

***The Lord’s Prayer**

MR

[All turn towards altar]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

[Chad center chancel]

***Passing of the Peace**

CTP

When we become cognizant of the fact that our everyday
experiences and our gradual becoming
unfolds at a pace that can’t be corralled in by clock time,
then we can accept that slowing down and being present
with the season of life that we are flowing through,
is necessary.

Even the steps that seem unnecessary, become a part
of the sacred practice of loving where we are -
in this moment and time.

[adpt/enfleshed]

This morning,
May the Peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

[Meg to lectern]

Reading from Our Religious Tradition

from the Prophet Amos

MR

Listen with your whole hearts to this ancient text from the Book of Amos
[Bold and bright]

"But let justice roll on like a river, righteousness like a never-failing stream!"

This is the simple and complex wisdom of the ancestors.

Thanks be to God!

[Christoph transition Chad to center chancel]

Prayers with the People

CTP

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

We are inseparable from generations past
and generations future.

The lives of the ones who came before us
are present all around us.

The needs of those to come...call upon us today.

What are we doing with all we have inherited -
the wonderful and the terrible?

What will we leave behind?

May the Holy things, the righteous things,
the things that make us brave in spirit
and fierce in hope
be our source of wisdom and guidance
as we strive to live faithfully
to the Sacred
to each other
to those past and yet come
in these days we have been given.

Let us now be in silence together...

[2 minutes Abe transition out of silence]

Prayer of Our Hearts

God of sleeping and waking,
in every state of our being, be near.

In our dreams, invite us to your creative vision of what could be:
of who we could become and what we could create together.
Nourish our imagination with glimpses of justice
that is full and healing that is rich.

In our waking up, may we do so with acceptance
of the day that closed, and embrace the day that is opening.
May your lovingkindness guide us in both accountability
to our friends, neighbors, and beloveds
and in grace that keeps us from being weighed down
by that which we can no longer control.

When we long to sleep but find ourselves awake
in the middle of the night, wrestling with the world,
our past, our future, or anxieties that do not yet
have names, may your Spirit of Peace embrace us.

When we struggle to stay awake - bone tired, soul heavy -
longing for the relief that is too far off, uphold us.

And then, O God, as we move through these cycles of rest and labor,
when they are balanced just right
and when they are all out of whack, be the constant
source that guides our life in peace, courage,
and the assurance of your hope for us.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen.

[Christoph transition for choir]

Meditation Anthem

“There Is Light” Clara Moniz

N.E.O. Festival Choir and Cathedral Choir

*“There is silence now where there once was colour There is light In place of fear There is space
where life was full and love replacing emptiness Hollow space overflowing The overflow and the
flood Overflowing Love” ~Clara Moniz*

[Abe transition Laura to pulpit]

Sermon

Truth Telling

LVF

[Abe transition as Chad & Laura go behind communion table]

The Eucharist and Blessings

LVF & CTP

Words of Invitation and Remembrance

Prayer of Blessing

Amen and Amen.

LVF: This table is for all, whether you have a lot of faith, etc....

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

[Meg to lectern]

Invitation to Generosity

MR

In this community we gather together each week because we share with God, a vision. It includes the belovedness of every one of us but it is also much bigger than any single life. The Kindom of God is a collective reality.

Each week, we are invited to share from our resources for the work we have been called to, together.

Offertory

“I’ve Learned To Sing”

Sam Scheibe

N.E.O. Festival Choir and Cathedral Choir

*“I’ve learned to sing a song of hope, I’ve said goodbye to despair,
I caught the note in a thrush’s throat, I sang---and the world was fair!
I’ve learned to sing a song of joy It bends the skies to me,
The song of joy is the song of hope Grown to maturity.
I’ve learned to laugh away my tears As through the dark I go
For love and laughter conquer fears My heart has come to know.
I’ve learned a song of happiness It is a song of love For love alone is happiness
And happiness is love.” ~Georgia Douglass Johnson*

[All turn towards altar]

*Doxology

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator’s praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

[Meg to lectern]

***Prayer of Offering**

MR

*May it ever be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen.*

Please be seated

[Laura center chancel]

Life at First Church

LVF &CTP

Words of Blessing

LVF

Choral Response “Ka Sise Fun Iwenumo Emi Wa” Yoruba hymn, arr. Damilola Odebiyi
N.E.O. Festival Choir and Cathedral Choir

*“In vanity we hope after worldly promises that vanish. Let us join together to bring about the
beloved community of the divine. God has promised the fruits of these labors. Amen!”*

[Choir mics on for hymn leaders]

***Hymn for the Journey**

[Chad center chancel to say: please be seated for the postlude]

Postlude

Improvisation

Dr. Abraham Ross, *Guest Organist*

Inside The Music

